and children like captives, and driving them out noisily in front of them, they made their escape among the Mughal foot soldiers who were also leading out prisoners.

The massacre of the civilian population of Chittor would be the only instance in which Akbar would indulge in this aberrant scorched earth policy in what would be a long and eventful reign. It remains a profoundly disquieting episode for modern readers but the Mughal Empire was still being formed, in the furnace of battles, mystic episodes, and past legacies. In February 1568, Akbar had fought personally for four long months, increasingly incensed by what he saw as the obduracy of the besieged forces and the great loss of lives the Mughal troops suffered. De la Garza points out that ‘it was expected that a besieged enemy would surrender soon after a practicable breach was made in their defences. If the assailants were forced to take their objective by storm, the consequences for the defenders were usually dire.’ There was also an elemental misalignment between the two sides in the understanding of bravery and battle tactics. For the Central Asian warriors, tactical defensive strategies and withdrawal in case of overwhelming odds were essential battle skills. They were contemptuous of what they saw as heedless aggression as exemplified by notions of European chivalry and Rajput valour. As a later Padshah, Aurangzeb, would explain:

> The Turani people have ever been soldiers. They feel no suspicion, despair or shame when commanded to make a retreat in the very midst of a fight, which means, in other words, ‘drawing the arrow back,’ and they are a hundred stages remote from the crass stupidity of the Hindustanis, who would part with their heads but not leave their positions.

For the Rajputs, meanwhile, the battle was a divine furnace, a conduit to an immortal life which was the destiny of those who died on the battlefield. For Akbar, the defeat of Chittor and the massacre of all those who resisted, coming after three years of persistent Uzbek and mirza rebellions, was intended to be seen as a fiery and clear message to all those who stood against him.

Akbar stayed for three days in Chittor, declaring it a sarkar of the Mughal Empire, and placing it in the charge of Asaf Khan. It is said he removed the symbols of its sovereignty, its great wooden doorways, and the